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Sports and Adventure Activities

The Indian Army has traditionally been the fostering ground for many luminaries in sports and adventure activities. In fact, these activities are the bedrock of regimental soldiering. In order to create the esprit de corps, camaraderie, leadership qualities, self-confidence and perseverance to achieve the assigned mission despite the challenges, the army has encouraged sport and outdoor activities.

After independence, army sportsmen dominated in athletics and field games. Dhyan Chand and Shankar Lakshman (hockey), Milkha Singh and Sriram Singh (athletics), Narinder Kumar and M.S. Kohli (mountaineering) and Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore, Olympic silver medallist, are a few of our legendary sportsmen from the armed forces. In the early 1950s, my father discovered the athlete in Milkha Singh, when he joined the EME Centre in Secunderabad as a recruit. Dad was his company commander and he nurtured young Milkha like a son. As kids we simply loved to see him running, and practically winning all the sprints at the station sports meets. In two years he rose to be our national champion in 400 metres, and thereafter made history at the Rome Olympics – and became known as 'the flying Sikh'. Unfortunately, the army's priority and focus of attention got totally reoriented to the operational side after the wars in 1962, 1965 and 1971. Besides, we needed a lot of funds for the creation of modern sports facilities, equipment, coaching and foreign exposure to produce international-level sportsmen. This was not forthcoming from any quarters. Consequently, the standard of sports deteriorated.